

91 Amos

A shepherd from Judah who thundered for justice in Israel's richest days.

Amos was not a professional prophet. He was a herdsman and a tender of sycamore fig trees from Tekoa, a small town in Judah. Around 760 BC God called him north to the kingdom of Israel. Under King Jeroboam II, Israel was strong and wealthy, and its worship was busy. But the rich were crushing the poor, courts were bought, and religion had become a show. Amos said plainly that God would not accept songs and sacrifices from people who trampled the needy. When the priest of Bethel told him to go home, Amos refused to be silenced. His book ends with a promise that God would one day raise up David's fallen house.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Amos</i> , often explained as "burden-bearer"
Home	Tekoa, in the hills of Judah south of Bethlehem (Amos 1:1)
Work	Herdman and "gatherer of sycamore fruit" (Amos 7:14)
When	Days of Uzziah of Judah and Jeroboam II of Israel, "two years before the earthquake," c. 760 BC (Amos 1:1)
Key places	Bethel, Samaria, Tekoa
Key people	Jeroboam II; Amaziah the priest of Bethel
Main passages	Amos 1–9
New Testament	Acts 7:42–43; 15:15–17

"But let judgment run down as waters, and righteousness as a mighty stream."
Amos 5:24, KJV

The life of Amos

Dates are approximate (BC). The earthquake in Amos 1:1 was remembered for centuries (Zechariah 14:5). Many scholars link it to signs of a strong earthquake found at sites such as Hazor, dated c. 760 BC.

Before his call <i>At Tekoa</i>	● Herdsmen and farmer Amos keeps flocks and tends sycamore figs. He is no prophet and no prophet's son. <i>Amos 1:1; 7:14</i>
c. 762 BC <i>Two years before the earthquake</i>	● Called north The LORD takes him from following the flock and says, "Go, prophesy unto my people Israel." <i>Amos 1:1; 7:15</i>
c. 762 BC <i>In Israel</i>	● Judgment on the nations He announces judgment on Israel's neighbours, then on Judah, and finally on Israel itself, for three transgressions and for four. <i>Amos 1:3-2:16</i>
In Israel	● Visions of judgment He sees locusts and fire and pleads for Israel, and God relents. Then he sees a plumbline, and God says he will not pass by them again. <i>Amos 7:1-9</i>
At Bethel	● Confronted by the priest Amaziah reports him to the king and orders him back to Judah. Amos answers with a word of judgment on Amaziah and on Israel. <i>Amos 7:10-17</i>
c. 760 BC <i>Two years later</i>	● The earthquake The earthquake comes, remembered long after as the one in the days of Uzziah. <i>Amos 1:1; Zechariah 14:5</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Amos was from Judah but preached in Israel. That made him an outsider, which is part of why Amaziah told him to go home.

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- 1 Left his flocks.** God called an ordinary working man, and he went. *Amos 7:14-15*
 - 2 Spoke to the nations.** He named the cruelties of Damascus, Gaza, Tyre, Edom, Ammon and Moab, then turned the same judgment on Judah and Israel. *Amos 1:3-2:16*
 - 3 Defended the poor.** He condemned those who "sold the righteous for silver, and the poor for a pair of shoes." *Amos 2:6-7; 5:11-12*
 - 4 Rebuked empty worship.** He said God hated their feasts and would not hear their songs while justice was missing. *Amos 5:21-24*
 - 5 Called them to seek God.** "Seek ye me, and ye shall live," the LORD said through him. *Amos 5:4-6, 14-15*
 - 6 Prayed for Israel.** At the vision of locusts he cried, "O Lord GOD, forgive, I beseech thee." At the vision of fire he pleaded again. Both times God relented. *Amos 7:1-6*
 - 7 Stood his ground at Bethel.** When told to flee, he explained that the LORD had sent him and gave the priest God's word. *Amos 7:10-17*
 - 8 Promised restoration.** He foretold that God would raise up "the tabernacle of David that is fallen" and plant his people in their land. *Amos 9:11-15*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Amos.

Old Testament

Amos 1–9	The book of his prophecies and visions
2 Kings 14:23–29	The reign of Jeroboam II, his setting
Zechariah 14:5	The earthquake "in the days of Uzziah" remembered
Echo: Hosea 1:1	Hosea spoke to Israel in the same years
Echo: Micah 6:8; Isaiah 1:11–17	Justice and mercy over empty worship

New Testament

Acts 7:42–43	Stephen quotes Amos 5:25–27 on wilderness idolatry
Acts 15:15–17	James quotes Amos 9:11–12 on including the Gentiles
Echo: James 5:1–6	A warning to rich oppressors that sounds like Amos
Echo: Matthew 5:23–24	Be reconciled before bringing your gift

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Amos say about himself when Amaziah told him to go home (Amos 7:14–15)?
2. *Understand:* Why would God reject worship from people who were cheating the poor (Amos 5:21–24)?
3. *Apply:* Amos spoke up though he was an outsider. Where might God be asking you to speak up for someone?
4. *Apply:* Look at your money and time. What is one concrete way to do justice this month?